

Shorebirds

The hordes of marine animals that spend their lives buried in sandy tidal beaches provide a feast for shorebirds feeding on the sand at low tide. Many of these birds have long bills for probing deep into soft sand or mud, and long legs that are ideal for wading in shallow water. A few are highly adapted for a particular feeding technique. Other shorebirds specialize in eating the shellfish that live on rocky shores, or snapping up insects and other small animals feeding on the debris washed up on the beach by the waves.

Ruddy turnstone

Beachcomber

Length 9 in (23 cm)

Range Worldwide

Habitat Mainly stony shores

Flocks of these small coastal birds work their way along the shore, using their short, strong bills to flick pebbles and seashells aside and seize any animals that they find. They often investigate the heaps of seaweed washed up on the shore at the high-tide mark, picking at dead fish and crabs, and chasing after seaweed flies and sandhoppers.

▼ CAMOUFLAGE COLORS

Perched on a rock, a turnstone is easy to see. But its colors make it almost invisible on weed-strewn shores.



▼ FINE FEATHERS

The roseate spoonbill was once threatened by hunting for its glorious pink and white plumage.



Crab plover

Shell cracker



Length 16 in (40 cm)

Range Indian Ocean

Habitat Sandy beaches and dunes

As its name indicates, this black and white shorebird specializes in catching and eating crabs. It has an extra-strong bill that it uses to crack open shells, and even feeds crabs to its young. It lives on tropical sandy coasts all year round, breeding in dense, noisy colonies on the shore. Unusually for a shorebird, the crab plover digs nesting burrows in the sand above the high tideline.